speakers using voice assistants like Google Assistant, Siri, Bixby and Alexa have added to the popularity of voice search. According to Google's latest data, 60 per cent of Indian users use voice assistants on their smartphones and Hindi is the second most common language used on Google Assistant. According to data from market research firm Grand View Research, the Indian voice assistant market was estimated to be around $109.5 million (Rs 958 crore) in 2023, with growth projected to reach $585.2 million (Rs 5,121 crore) by 2030.

TECH-CHARGED AI

There may be no surprise in the primacy of voice, but the technological advancements showcased by voice assistants are impressive. "Earlier, voice assistants like Siri or Google Now could answer basic questions. The speech recognition was not accurate too," says Amit Agarwal, a Google Developer Expert. Today, speech recognition has drastically improved, coupled with the intelligence imparted by generative AI (or GenAI). Google Assistant, for example, can now perform over a million actions and can understand complex dialogue. This has changed how a person uses it. Data shows that Google Assistant queries are 200 times more conversational and 40 times more action-oriented compared to their search engine. "Voice assistants can now understand context and handle complex multi-step tasks. You could ask your voice assistant to book an Italian restaurant, add the booking to your calendar and notify your family," adds Agarwal.

Similarly, Apple Intelligence is powering the voice assistant Siri; Amazon is launching a new GenAI-powered Alexa; Facebook has embedded a voice-enabled Meta AI into Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp and Meta's Ray-Ban Smart Glasses; and Google has rolled out Gemini on Android phones. All these assistants combine the ease of voice with the intelligence of GenAI.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

"MY DAUGHTER TALKS TO VOICE ASSISTANTS LIKE SHE WOULD TO A HUMAN. THEY ARE HER DIGITAL BEST FRIEND"

ABHISHEK BHATNAGAR *40*
Youtuber; founder & editor-in-chief of @gadgetstouse

Voice Assistant used: Alexa, Siri, Google Assistant

SPEAKING TO CONVERSING

The integration of GenAI with voice assistants has created an interface between the backend AI (which analyses massive amounts of information and recognises patterns) and users. The result is a device that no longer just spouts information but also creates new content like images, text, videos and music. "We have been using AI at the backend for a long time. Now, these new voice-enabled assistants are interfacing between that body of knowledge and a human on the other side," says Prasanto K. Roy, vice president at NASSCOM (National Association of Software and Service Companies). "Generative AI like ChatGPT and DeepSeek have turned backend AI, which powers our search engines, into a human-like brain we can tap into using voice," he adds.

The GenAI boom was kickstarted by ChatGPT in late 2022. According to media and information platform Inc42, India's GenAI market is projected to surpass $17 billion (Rs 1.47 lakh crore) by 2030 from $1.1 billion (Rs 9,522 crore) in 2023, growing at a CAGR (compound annual growth rate) of 48 per cent. A 2025 survey of 92,000 Indians from 309 districts by community social media platform LocalCircles shows that one out of two Indians uses GenAI platforms.

Take Apple Intelligence and its integration in Siri. The new writing tools it offers can summarise a lecture in seconds, shorten a long group thread and rewrite different versions of text. Siri can even make a custom movie based on a simple voice description. In other words, turn your thoughts into visuals simply by hearing them.

These days, voice assistants can